corporations governing roughly 712 sq. km of urban sprawl between them.

While the corporations will manage their local affairs, overall planning will rest with the newly created Greater Bengaluru Authority (GBA). It is conceived as a platform to bring together mayors and other authorities responsible for civic utilities—an attempt to address Bengaluru's chronic problem of multiple bodies functioning in silos. The three-tiered structure of wards, corporations and the apex GBA is also meant to avoid the pitfalls seen in Delhi, which split its municipal body in 2012 only to reunify it a decade later.

BATTLELINES DRAWN

Since the previous council's term ended in 2020, Bengaluru has been run by administrators, even as residents voiced growing frustration over deteriorating infrastructure. For Abdul Wajid, president of the Bengaluru North District Congress Committee and a former corporator who was among the petitioners before the SC, the restructuring offers promise, albeit with challenges. "It's a beginning. We don't know how the turf is," he says.

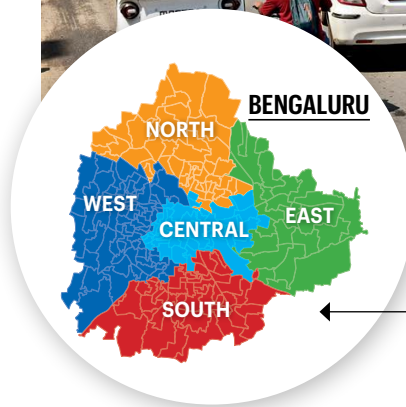
Political signals suggest parties view the contest as unusually high stakes. On January 20, BJP national president Nitin Nabin tasked former national general secretary and RSS veteran Ram Madhav with overseeing the GBA election. Fresh from wresting control of the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation, the party appears keen for another high-profile urban battle. Madhav underscored the importance soon after, writing on X that the election would be "no less than an assembly battle".

The Congress, which governs the state, had moved early in anticipation and invited applications from aspirants by 2025-end. Karnataka deputy chief minister D.K. Shivakumar, who also oversees Bengaluru's development, has expressed confidence that the party will win all five corporations. Yet the BJP retains an edge: of the 27 assembly constituencies covering the GBA area, 16 are held by its legislators.



URBAN GRIDLOCK Traffic snarl chokes Bengaluru's Yelahanka, reflecting the mounting civic strain

HEMANT MISHRA



Takeaways

- **The Supreme Court has ordered the Karnataka govt to hold long-delayed Bengaluru civic election by June 30**
- **Polls will be held to five new corporations that replace the 'unwieldy' Bruhat Bengaluru Mahanagara Palike**
- **The BJP retains an edge: of the 27 assembly constituencies that cover the municipal limits, 16 are held by its MLAs and 11 by the ruling Congress**

For smaller players, the redrawn map presents an opening. Draft electoral rolls published in January show nearly 9 million voters across 369 wards. That's almost double the 198 wards that existed during the last civic election in 2015. "Earlier, the ward sizes had grown to ridiculous numbers...there were some wards on the outskirts which had 80,000–90,000 people. It was almost like an assembly constituency," says Prithvi Reddy, state convenor of the Aam Aadmi Party in Karnataka, which is preparing to fight its first civic election in Bengaluru. "We are hoping to bring out voters by making the elections issue-based and hyper-local."

It is early yet, but the contours of a competitive race are beginning to take shape. On it depends whether political renewal in Bengaluru can translate into civic repair. ■